

Picking who to hire based on how sure of themselves they sound

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

Sounding sure of themselves comes more from **being overconfident** than from being good at the job. Liking someone also shifts how careful or honest they seem to you.

THE GOAL

You want the person who'll do the work well. Write down what each one actually said about the job, separately from how they made you feel.

CHECKLIST

You've got quotes from a few tradespeople and you're about to decide who to call back.

- ☐ Lay out whatever you kept from each visit, quotes, texts, business cards, in front of you.
- ☐ For each person, write two short lists: what they said about the job, and how they made you feel.
- ☐ Cross out the 'how they made you feel' list; it says nothing about who is better at the trade.
- ☐ For anyone who paused or corrected themselves, look at what they said right after the pause, not the pause itself.
- ☐ If any answer was flat-out wrong, not just hesitant or slow, cross that person off your list.
- ☐ Send each remaining person the **same specific question** about the trickiest part of the job, then compare their answers side by side.
- ☐ Pick one concrete detail someone mentioned, a material, a step, a past address, and check it with one call or text now.
- ☐ Before you decide, write down one real reason the person you're leaning toward might not be the best pick.
- ☐ If two people still look even after that, **let the detail you verified decide it**, not who you liked talking to more.
- ☐ Write down the one specific thing that decided it for you, not just 'he seemed sure of himself.'
- ☐ Write down, for next time, the one question that told you something real about someone's actual skill.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** The behaviors that make a person look competent come more from **being overconfident** than from being good at the job.
- 2** Liking someone changes how you rate their completely separate qualities, like how careful or honest they seem, usually without you noticing.
- 3** Talking with someone face-to-face mostly makes you feel sure of your read on them.

Why sounding sure gets mistaken for skill

KNOW

The behaviors that make a person look competent come more from **being overconfident** than from being good at the job.

Genuinely skilled people didn't reliably act more confident, so their competence was easy to miss. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Sounding sure of yourself makes you look more competent to the people watching you.

Confidence changes how competent you look. Your odds of being right don't move. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Give someone a pass for a single pause or self-correction, then judge the answer that follows it.

Judge the specific answer they land on once the pause ends, never the pause itself. [Source 2](#)

What talking to them face to face really does to your judgment

KNOW

Liking someone changes how you rate their completely separate qualities, like how careful or honest they seem, usually without you noticing.

Judge their carefulness or honesty from something you wrote down, never from memory of how much you liked them. [Source 3](#)

DON'T

Talking with someone face-to-face mostly makes you feel sure of your read on them.

People given interview impressions along with test scores **grew more confident in their predictions**, without predicting any more accurately. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Feeling very sure about a pick sometimes goes with worse outcomes.

People whose confidence in a bet outran their real odds of winning ended up with smaller payoffs overall. [Source 4](#)

A better way to size them up

DO

Ask them to walk you through exactly how they'd handle the trickiest part of the job.

Trying to explain how something works drops people's own rated understanding of it, even right after they felt sure. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

Don't count on your gut here. A bluff rarely shows in how someone carries themselves while answering.

Across hundreds of tests of people trying to catch each other lying, the average guess was right barely more than half the time. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <http://learnmoore.org/papers/Anderson%20Brion%20Kennedy%20Moore%202012.pdf>
2. <https://www.psypost.org/confident-gestures-fail-to-mask-the-uncertainty-signaled-by-speech-disfluencies/>
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Hiring someone to work on your home at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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